CLASS NOTES · TADABBUR

Surah *Al-Fil*

Thursday, 8 October 2026 | Surah ke-105 · 5 ayat · Makkiyyah | *Al-Fil* = the elephant

IN SHORT

- An army with elephants came to destroy the Kaabah; Allah sent birds.
- "I'm the lord of the camels — the House has its own Lord." Do your part, leave the rest to Allah.
- If Allah helps you, no one can defeat you (3:160).

> **For parents:** there's an interactive story of this surah for children — **Year of the Elephant** (shakinakushairi-code.github.io/ilm-notes/kids) — with tap-through scenes, a matching game for the ayat, and notes on how to use it.

1. Text & meaning

أَلَمْ تَرَ كَيْفَ فَعَلَ رَبُّكَ بِأَصْحَابِ الْفِيلِ ﴿١﴾ أَلَمْ يَجْعَلْ كَيْدَهُمْ فِي تَضْلِيلٍ ﴿٢﴾
وَأَرْسَلَ عَلَيْهِمْ طَيْرًا أَبَابِيلَ ﴿٣﴾ تَرْمِيهِم بِحِجَارَةٍ مِّن سِجِّيلٍ ﴿٤﴾ فَجَعَلَهُمْ كَعَصْفٍ
مَّأْكُولٍ ﴿٥﴾

WORD BY WORD

1

أَلَمْ	تَرَ	كَيْفَ	فَعَلَ	رَبُّكَ	بِأَصْحَابِ
tidakkah	engkau perhatikan	bagaimana	telah bertindak	Tuhanmu	terhadap tentera

الْفِيلِ
bergajah

Tidakkah engkau perhatikan bagaimana Tuhanmu telah bertindak terhadap tentera bergajah?

2

أَلَمْ	يَجْعَلْ	كَيْدَهُمْ	فِي تَضْلِيلٍ
bukankah	Dia telah menjadikan	tipu daya mereka	sia-sia

Bukankah Dia telah menjadikan tipu daya mereka sia-sia?

3

وَأَرْسَلَ	عَلَيْهِمْ	طَيْرًا	أَبَابِيلَ
dan Dia menghantar	kepada mereka	burung	berbondong-bondong

Dan Dia menghantar kepada mereka burung berbondong-bondong,

4

تَرْمِيهِم	بِحِجَارَةٍ	مِّن سِجِّيلٍ
yang melempari mereka	dengan batu	daripada tanah yang dibakar

yang melempari mereka dengan batu daripada tanah yang dibakar,

5

فَجَعَلَهُمْ	كَعَصْفٍ	مَّأْكُولٍ
lalu Dia menjadikan mereka	seperti daun-daun / jerami	yang dimakan (habis)

lalu Dia menjadikan mereka seperti daun-daun (jerami) yang dimakan.

AL-FIL 105:1–5

2. The story — as the sirah books tell it

The Quran gives the core in five ayat. The details below are from the sirah (Ibn Ishaq, in Ibn Hisham's Sirah, retold in Tafsir Ibn Kathir) — history passed down by the scholars of sirah, without sahih chains. Tell it as history, not as hadith.

ABRAHA AND THE TALLEST CHURCH

Abraha ruled Yemen for the king of Abyssinia. Every year he watched the Arabs travel to the Kaabah, and he wanted them to come to *him* instead. So he built a church in San'a, taller and grander than anything the Arabs had seen — so tall it was called **al-Qullays**, because you had to tip your head right back to see the top. All to show it was better than the Kaabah and to **pull people's attention to Yemen**.

An Arab man dirtied the church. Abraha was furious and swore to destroy the Kaabah. He set out with a huge army and war elephants; the biggest, at the front, was called **Mahmud**. Tribes tried to stop him along the way and lost.

ABDUL MUTTALIB AND THE 200 CAMELS

Abraha's men seized the animals grazing outside Makkah, including 200 camels belonging to **Abdul Muttalib**, chief of Quraysh and grandfather of the Prophet ﷺ. When Abdul Muttalib came to meet him, Abraha was so impressed by him that he stepped down from his throne and sat beside him. Then Abdul Muttalib asked only for his camels.

> Abraha mocked him: "You speak to me about camels, and say nothing about the House I've come to destroy?" Abdul Muttalib replied: **"I am the lord of the camels. The House has a Lord who will protect it."**

He told the people of Makkah to go up into the mountains, then held the ring of the Kaabah's door and made du'a — the meaning reported: *"O Allah, a man protects what is his. So protect what is Yours."*

MAHMUD KNEELS

In the morning, the elephant **knelt** and would not walk towards Makkah. Turned towards Yemen, Syam or the east, it would get up and go — but towards Makkah, it would not move.

> *When the Prophet's ﷺ camel al-Qaswa' knelt on the way to Makkah at Hudaibiyah and people said she was being stubborn, he said she was not — that wasn't her nature:* ***"Dia ditahan oleh (Allah) yang telah menahan gajah."***
>
> BUKHARI 2731 · SAHIH

And in the Arabic of Bukhari 2434, the Prophet ﷺ said Allah held back the elephant from Makkah.

THE BIRDS — AND ABRAHA'S END

Flocks of birds came (*ababil*), each — the reports say — carrying three stones the size of a chickpea or lentil. The army was left **like chewed-up straw**.

Abraha was struck too. The reports say his men carried him back towards Yemen as his body fell apart, piece by piece — fingertip by fingertip — until he reached San'a as small and weak as a baby bird, and then died.

Where reports differ: the number of elephants (one, eight or twelve); what happened to the church (one man dirtied it, or in another report some young men's fire burnt it); and Abraha's return — the reports checked say he was carried, not that he crawled.

THAT SAME YEAR

The Kaabah stood exactly where it always had. And the Prophet ﷺ was born in Makkah that year — the Year of the Elephant.

This is the well-known view of the sirah scholars. The hadith often cited for it (Tirmidhi 3619) has a disputed chain: al-Albani graded it weak, adh-Dhahabi hasan.

3. Linking it to Ali 'Imran 3:160

إِن يَنصُرْكُمُ اللَّهُ فَلَا غَالِبَ لَكُمْ ۖ وَإِن يَخْذُلْكُمْ فَمَن ذَا الَّذِي يَنصُرُكُم مِّن بَعْدِهِ ۗ وَعَلَى اللَّهِ فَلْيَتَوَكَّلِ الْمُؤْمِنُونَ

> *"Jika Allah menolong kamu, maka tiada sesiapa yang dapat mengalahkan kamu; dan jika Dia membiarkan kamu, maka siapakah yang dapat menolong kamu selepas-Nya? Dan kepada Allah sahajalah hendaknya orang-orang beriman bertawakkal."*
>
> ALI 'IMRAN 3:160

	ABRAHA	THE KAABAH
Soldiers	A huge army	None stayed
Elephants	Mahmud and more	None
Weapons & walls	Spears, swords, a whole camp	An empty city
Allah's help	**No**	**Yes**

The elephant wasn't the strong one, and neither was the bird. **The strong One is Allah**, who made them both — and told the elephant to kneel and the bird to fly.

4. Related hadith

احْفَظِ اللَّهَ يَحْفَظْكَ ... وَإِذَا سَأَلْتَ فَاسْأَلِ اللَّهَ، وَإِذَا اسْتَعَنْتَ فَاسْتَعِنْ بِاللَّهِ

To the young Ibn 'Abbas, riding behind him: "Jagalah (perintah) Allah, nescaya Allah menjagamu... Apabila engkau meminta, mintalah kepada Allah; apabila engkau memohon pertolongan, mohonlah kepada Allah." And if all the people gathered to harm you, they could only harm you with what Allah has already written for you.

TIRMIDHI 2516 · SAHIH (AT-TIRMIDHI: HASAN SAHIH)

"Kalaulah kamu bertawakkal kepada Allah dengan sebenar-benar tawakkal, nescaya Dia memberi rezeki kepada kamu sebagaimana Dia memberi rezeki kepada burung — keluar pagi dalam keadaan lapar, pulang petang dalam keadaan kenyang."

TIRMIDHI 2344 · SAHIH (AL-ALBANI)

Notice the birds still **fly out**. Trusting Allah means doing our part, then leaving the rest to Him — just like Abdul Muttalib: he asked for his camels and moved his people to safety (his part), then left the House to its Lord.

حَسْبُنَا اللَّهُ وَنِعْمَ الْوَكِيلُ

"Cukuplah Allah bagi kami, dan Dialah sebaik-baik tempat berserah." — said by Nabi Ibrahim a.s. when thrown into the fire, and by Nabi Muhammad ﷺ when told an army had gathered against him.

ALI 'IMRAN 3:173 · BUKHARI 4563

5. Teaching it like the Prophet ﷺ taught

I wanted to pass this on to my kids the way the Prophet ﷺ taught his companions:

WHAT HE DID	EVIDENCE
Asked a question before giving the answer	Which tree is like a Muslim? He let them think first (Bukhari 61)
Drew pictures to explain an idea	A square and lines to explain a person's life and hopes (Bukhari 6417)
Repeated important words three times	So they would be understood (Bukhari 95)
Taught a child directly, in short sentences	"Wahai anak muda, aku ajarkan kepadamu beberapa kalimah..." (Tirmidhi 2516)

Reflections

- **Everyone has an "elephant"** — the thing that feels too big. The surah reminds us Who is bigger than it.
- **Our part, and Allah's part.** Abdul Muttalib didn't sit and wait: he did what was in his hands, then made du'a and trusted Allah with the rest.

- **Wanting to be the biggest made Abraha the smallest.** He built the tallest church to pull attention to himself — and ended up weaker than a baby bird.

Personal notes from the Tadabbur class, 8/10/2026, compiled for revision and sharing. Sirah details are reports from the sirah books, not hadith. All ayat and hadith checked against quran.com, sunnah.com and dorar.net. Any mistakes are mine — please tegur. والله أعلم